



Participant Information Sheet

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1. Research Project Title

Sequential Transfer Learning for Medicinal Plant Identification: Endangered Species Protection and Sustainable Harvesting

2. Background, aims of project

Who are we?

We are a computing science student and research team at the University of Stirling working on an artificial intelligence project focused on medicinal plant identification.

What is this project about?

This project develops a machine learning system that can identify medicinal plant species from leaf images. The system provides predictions along with a "confidence score" (a percentage indicating how certain the model is about its prediction). While the primary work involves training and testing the model on public datasets, we want to understand how clearly the system presents its predictions and confidence scores to users. This is where we need your help.

3. Why have I been invited to take part?

You have been invited because you are a University of Stirling student aged 18 or over. We are looking for a diverse range of participants to help us evaluate how understandable our interface and model outputs are. Your background does not matter—we want feedback from people with different perspectives.

4. What will participation involve?

What will you be asked to do?

If you agree to participate, you will:

1. **Attend one session** lasting approximately **20–30 minutes**
2. **View a series of example outputs** from our medicinal plant identification model
3. **Complete 5 short tasks**, For example:
 - Look at a leaf image and the model's prediction and rate how clear the presentation is
 - Answer simple questions like "Does the confidence score make sense to you?"
 - Indicate which of two different result layouts is easier to understand
4. **Answer a brief questionnaire** with 3–4 short questions about clarity and usability, plus an optional comment box

Will you need any special skills or knowledge?

No. You do not need any knowledge of plants, machine learning, or any technical background. This is a general usability evaluation.

5. Confidentiality and Data Handling

What information will be collected?

- Your **questionnaire responses** (ratings and optional comments)
- Your **age group** (e.g., 18–25 years old)
- Your **field of study** (optional)
- Whether you have studied biology before (optional)

We will NOT collect:

- Your name
- Your student ID
- Your phone number, email, or any contact details
- Any other personal identifying information

How will your data be stored?

- You will be assigned an **anonymous participant code** (e.g., P1, P2, P3, etc.)
- Only this code will appear on your questionnaire
- Your responses will be stored on a **password-protected computer**
- Only the researcher and supervisor will have access

6. Voluntary Participation and Withdrawal

Can I withdraw or change my mind?

Yes. You can withdraw from the study:

During the session: Simply tell the researcher you want to stop

Up to 1 week after the session: Contact the researcher via email and request withdrawal

After 1 week: Your data will have been anonymized and cannot be withdrawn

7. Possible Benefits and Risks

Possible benefits:

- You will contribute to improving interface design for AI applications
- You may gain insight into how machine learning systems present results

Possible risks:

- **Very low risk.** This is similar to testing a prototype website or app
- No sensitive or distressing topics are involved
- No physical, psychological, or social risks

You will be given a copy of this information sheet to keep.

Thank you for your participation.